

Lone STAR

In going it alone, Mayawati has taken a gamble which fits in perfectly with her prime ministerial ambition

If any political party's symbol is descriptive of its leader, then the BSP's elephant comes the closest. BSP boss Mayawati stomps through the political jungle like she is its most powerful denizen. For her, Lucknow is just a stop en route to Delhi. To achieve that, she has also ensured that she has no permanent allies or permanent enemies, banking on her social engineering skills to get other non-BJP/Congress parties to back her bid. At her meetings, she asks the voters to "help me to reach Delhi and also help change your destiny".

It's her own destiny that she believes is foretold. When she became the Chief Minister of Uttar Pradesh for the fourth time two years ago, she announced her target: *Ab ki baari Delhi hamari* (Delhi will be ours this time). Her ambition and ruthless politics may be one way of achieving her goal but it's also her biggest handicap. She joined the club of regional parties branded the UNPA comprising the Left, TDP, TRS, RLD and JD(s) after the Left broke away from the UPA on the nuclear deal issue, but her pre-condition that she would be the prime ministerial candidate ended that dream.

Undeterred, she reinitiated a move to pressure the newly formed Third Front comprising the Left parties, TDP, TRS, AIADMK and JD(s) to back her for the top post but after they balked, she announced she would fight the polls alone with a new social combination of Dalit-Muslim. This was part of her new strategy based on the belief that she cannot take the wholesale support of Brahmins for granted.

This is a do-or-die battle for her and she ploughs a lone electoral furrow. She has criss-crossed the country, campaigning ceaselessly. Her goal is clear judging by the fact that she has put up 500 candidates across the country—more than the BJP and

Congress, looking to double her current Lok Sabha tally of 19 based on the fact that the BSP's Lok Sabha vote share went up from 1.80 per cent in 1991 to 5.33 per cent in 2004.

Yet, naked ambition, ruthlessness and drive may not be enough to get her to Race Course Road. She has always been vague on policy matters and despite being the chief minister of the largest state in the country, she is yet to show interest in governance, allowing a group of trusted bureaucrats to run the government, along with her key adviser Satish Chandra Mishra. But only last week, Sudhir Goel, her strategist, summed up the mood in the form of a



PARTY SLOGAN

AB KI BAARI DILLI HAMARI
 (Delhi will be ours this time)

500

is the number of candidates the BSP has fielded across the country, compared to the Congress's 440 and the BJP's 422.

rhyme: Congress-BJP
 ast/Samajwadi Party
 past/Maya ka haathi mast
 (Congress-BJP have been eclipsed/the SP is demoralised/ Mayawati's elephant is on the march).

That may be true but there are a lot of obstacles in the way, not the least being her arrogance and dictatorial attitude. None of the non-BJP, non-Congress formations are ready to project her as their candidate for the top post. Nor, for that matter, have the voters indicated that she is the Chosen One. In making her ambitions so public and so soon, Mayawati may have queered the pitch for herself.

by Farzand Ahmed

Once voted to power, my government will guarantee *har haath ko kaam* (work to every hand).

MAYAWATI, BSP SUPREMO